

Sacred Heart Church Website — What's Next

A plain-language plan with costs, prepared for the Board. All work at the church rate of \$55.50/hr. The original website build is complete and paid in full — everything below is new and optional, offered so you can pick what fits the budget.

Where we are today

The new website is **live and secure at nhshc.ca**, with the church email working exactly as before — at **no ongoing cost**. It already has the welcome/history, About Us, Board of Directors, Documents, Cemetery, a donation section (CanadaHelps + e-Transfer), and an email-newsletter signup.

Nothing below is required to keep running. The church operates fully today. Everything that follows is about **growing reach and giving** — and it's laid out so you can stop at any budget line.

The strategy, in one paragraph

We looked at how small, volunteer-run parishes actually thrive. Three things stand out for a parish like ours: **(1) lean on email** — it's the channel you own and the one donors prefer (small parishes raise far more per email contact than through social media, and Facebook now shows a page to only ~2% of followers); **(2) activate the diaspora** — people with North Harbour roots who've moved away give out of identity and belonging, and a church is the natural way to reach them; and **(3) turn the cemetery into a year-round memorial-giving channel** — tribute/"in memory of" giving is common (about a third of donors give it) and a natural fit we're currently not using. Social media is optional and can wait.

The plan, by priority

Tier 1 — Highest value, lowest cost (*strongly recommended*)

Small tweaks to the **existing** site that directly drive subscribers and donations. Not required to operate — but the best return per dollar on this whole list.

Item	What it does	Hours	Cost
Memorial giving + "Cemetery Perpetual Care Fund"	Adds "In memory of / In honour of" giving and a named cemetery fund — taps the biggest underused giving source for a parish with a cemetery	1.5	~\$85

Item	What it does	Hours	Cost
Recurring-giving + tax-receipt wording	“\$10/month keeps the lights on and the cemetery cared for” + “instant CRA tax receipt” — both proven to lift giving	0.5	~\$30
Newsletter QR code + diaspora invitation	A scan-to-subscribe code for printed bulletins, and a “anyone with North Harbour roots” hook on the signup	1	~\$55
Tier 1 total		~3 hrs	~\$170

Note: the memorial-giving item also needs a quick ~10-minute setup in CanadaHelps (creating the “Cemetery Perpetual Care Fund”) by whoever manages the church’s CanadaHelps account — likely Mary Ann. Exact step-by-step instructions provided.

● Tier 2 — Custom Newsletter Template (*recommended next investment*)

Email is the highest-return channel we own, so it’s worth making it look like the church rather than a generic form. A branded, reusable template you fill in and send in a few clicks.

Step	What’s involved	Hours	Cost
Design	Translate the site’s look into an email-safe layout; one mockup round for approval	2	~\$111
Build	Hand-code the template (renders correctly even in Outlook); reusable blocks: header, story, image, button, footer	3	~\$167
Set up in email system (Kit)	Load it in; configure the required mailing-address footer, unsubscribe link, and branding	1	~\$55
Testing	Verify it looks right in Gmail, Apple Mail, Outlook, iPhone and Android	2	~\$111
How-to guide	A simple guide for composing a newsletter with the template	1	~\$55
Tier 2 total		~9 hrs	~\$500

● Tier 3 — News-Posting Portal (*optional — only if you want to post updates yourselves*)

Lets the board **log in and publish text + photo updates** straight to the website’s “Updates” area, no developer needed. Built **admin-only** (no public sign-up) on purpose — it keeps things simple, cheap, and **low cyber-risk**, since there are no public accounts to attack and almost no personal data stored.

The technology — in plain terms

The public website stays exactly where it is (GitHub Pages, free). We add a small, secure “back office” using **Supabase** — a well-established, open-source platform used by thousands of organizations — which provides three things on its **free tier**: a **database** (where the posts live), a **login system**, and **photo storage**. The posting screens are built with the same plain web technology the current site already uses (HTML, CSS, JavaScript) — no heavy frameworks, nothing exotic to maintain.

- **Where the data lives:** Supabase’s secure cloud (industry-standard, automatically backed up).
- **Who owns it:** the church — everything can be exported at any time, no lock-in.
- **Ongoing cost:** **\$0** on the free tier (more than enough for a parish’s posting volume).

The tools, section by section:

Section	What it covers	Technology used	Hours	Cost
Backend + database	Secure storage for posts and photos	Supabase — managed PostgreSQL database (free tier)	3	~\$165
Admin login	Sign in, sign out, password reset	Supabase Auth (email + password)	4	~\$222
Security layer	Ensures only published posts are ever public	PostgreSQL Row-Level Security (RLS) rules	4	~\$222
Posting dashboard	Create / edit / publish / delete posts	Vanilla JavaScript + the Supabase JS client (loaded via CDN); HTML/CSS forms styled to match the site	6	~\$333
Photo uploads	Upload + auto-resize, one photo per post	Supabase Storage + in-browser image resizing (Canvas API)	3	~\$167
Display on the site	Posts appear in the “Updates” area	JavaScript reading from Supabase, rendered into the existing page	4	~\$222
Mobile, accessibility & checks	Works on phones; safe and accessible	The site’s existing CSS design system ; responsive layout + ARIA accessibility	5	~\$278
Testing + your revisions	Full testing + 1–2 rounds of changes	Manual cross-browser/device testing (Chrome, Safari, Firefox, iOS, Android)	5	~\$278
Guide + go-live	“How to post” guide; publish to the live site	GitHub Pages + the existing GitHub Actions auto-deploy; written admin guide	3	~\$167
Contingency (20%)	Buffer for the security-critical parts	—	7	~\$389

Section	What it covers	Technology used	Hours	Cost
Tier 3 total			~44 hrs	~\$2,450

One honest note on upkeep: adding a login + database is a small new responsibility — occasional security and dependency updates. Budget roughly **~2–4 hrs/quarter** if you’d like me to keep it maintained. This is optional and separate from the build above; the site itself stays free to run.

● Reserved for the future (*not needed now*)

- **Public member logins + approval** (~+30 hrs / +\$1,600) — lets parishioners (not just the board) submit content. More “community feel,” but more cyber-risk and admin work. Easy to add later.
- **Photo galleries, events, and a calendar** — add only if the need appears.

What’s necessary vs. optional — the bottom line

	What	Cost
Necessary to operate	Nothing — the site is live and does the job today	\$0
Best value (recommended regardless)	Tier 1 quick wins	~\$170
Recommended investment	Tier 2 newsletter template	~\$500
Optional (when budget allows)	Tier 3 self-posting portal	~\$2,450
Future only	Public member logins, galleries, events	later

Pick-your-budget packages

Package	Includes	One-time	Ongoing
Essentials	Tier 1 quick wins	~\$170	\$0
Essentials + Newsletter	Tier 1 + Tier 2	~\$670	\$0
Everything	Tier 1 + Tier 2 + Tier 3	~\$3,120	\$0

Each item can be done as its own small piece, billed on completion — so the church pays as it goes and can stop at any line without leaving anything half-finished.

Top recommendations (cheap, high-impact)

1. **Commit to a consistent monthly email** — your highest-return channel, and the one that reaches the diaspora.
2. **Add a QR code to the bulletin** linking to the signup — the easiest way to grow the list from the pews.
3. **Add “In memory of / In honour of” giving + a Cemetery Perpetual Care Fund** — a natural fit we’re not yet using.
4. **Promote “in lieu of flowers” donations** with a direct link in obituaries/funeral notices.
5. **Run one annual diaspora “homecoming” giving campaign** (Christmas or a summer feast day).
6. **Lead every donation ask with monthly recurring giving.**
7. **Route donors to CanadaHelps** and advertise the **instant tax receipt** (and the tax savings).

(Worth skipping for now: text-message platforms, weekly emails, and a Facebook Page — too much upkeep for a volunteer board.)

Two housekeeping notes (for Melvin)

- **Downgrade the DreamHost plan to email-only** (~\$24/yr) to capture the planned savings — ideally before the **July 30** hosting renewal.
 - **Turn on domain auto-renewal** (currently off; the domain expires March 2027).
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Full research sources (on how small parishes handle news, subscribers, and donations) available on request.